

The Empty Chest

In a memory of Sergeant Briggs and Blackhoof Witherspine

The fortress had cost them several dozen men and two days, which Briggs considered a reasonable price for what they had taken. The walls were solid, the stores were full, and the enemy had left in sufficient haste to abandon a strongroom containing, among other things, a chest of campaign gold that the goblin supply corps had been tracking for three weeks.

Tusk had arrived personally for that one. He had counted the coin twice, recorded the figure in his ledger with the careful penmanship of a man who loved numbers the way other men loved their families, and then locked the chest and assigned Briggs's cavalry to guard it through the night.

"An honour," Tusk had said, with the smile of a man who meant something else entirely.

Briggs had said nothing and taken the assignment.

By the time the watch changed at midnight, the courtyard was quiet and the fires had burned to coals. Briggs was at the far end of the garrison hall with four soldiers, a guttering candle, and a set of dice that had seen more campaigns than most of the men present. The sounds coming from that corner of the hall were the sounds of a man winning steadily and without particular excitement, which was how Briggs always won — not with luck, but with the patient arithmetic of a man who had counted every side of every die he had ever owned.

It was, as Blackhoof had observed to himself on many occasions, the only time Briggs looked like he was enjoying anything.

Blackhoof watched from his place near the door, said nothing, and eventually slept.

Tusk arrived at dawn with two assistants and his ledger.

He unlocked the chest. Looked inside. And counted. Then he hissed and counted again, with the focused intensity of a man who believed the numbers might change if he approached them differently. They did not.

He closed the ledger and looked up at Briggs, who was standing with his flask and his usual expression of a man waiting for the world to finish whatever it had started.

"There appears to be a discrepancy," Tusk said.

"Does there."

"Roughly a third of the recorded sum." Tusk let the silence sit for a moment, then added, with the careful neutrality of a bureaucrat who knew exactly what he was implying: "Your unit held the assignment."

"We did."

"And you were... occupied. Through the night."

"I was."

"With dice."

"Among other things."

Tusk wrote something in his ledger. He did not say I accuse you, Sergeant Briggs. He did not need to. He simply wrote, and closed the ledger, and told Briggs that the matter would require a full accounting before the column moved, and walked away with the air of a man who had already decided how the accounting would end.

Briggs watched him go. Blackhoof said nothing.

That was the part Briggs noticed. Not the accusation — he had been accused of things before and had learned to treat it as weather, something that arrived and eventually passed. What he noticed was the silence beside him, and the particular quality of it.

He glanced at Blackhoof.

Blackhoof was looking at the chest.

"Say it," Briggs said.

"I didn't say anything."

"You're thinking it loudly."

A pause. "I know you didn't take it."

Briggs held the look for a moment. I know you didn't was not the same as I know you wouldn't, and both of them were aware of the difference. He put the flask away.

"Right," he said. "Then help me find out who did."

They started with who had known.

The chest's location had been recorded in Tusk's ledger, distributed to three officers, and mentioned in passing at the evening briefing — which had been attended by eleven people, one of whom was dead by midnight from a wound sustained in the assault, which simplified things somewhat.

Ten names. They crossed out Briggs's cavalry on the grounds that they had been present and visible all night. They crossed out Blackhoof on grounds Briggs didn't bother to state aloud. That left three with both knowledge and unaccounted time: a quartermaster's assistant named Dolg, a goblin engineer who had surveyed the strongroom that afternoon, and the garrison's own supply sergeant, who had surrendered the fortress and been held in the east wing under loose confinement.

They started with Dolg.

Dolg had a witness — two of them, in fact, both reliable, who placed him in the infirmary from the tenth hour until well past dawn with a fever that had left him barely functional.

The engineer had been working through the night on the gate mechanism, in full view of few soldiers who had been watching because the noise was preventing them from sleeping.

The garrison sergeant was confined, but the confinement was loose enough that it warranted a look. Briggs interviewed him for ten minutes in the east wing, came out, and shook his head. "He didn't know about the gold location. The briefing was after he surrendered." Blackhoof thought about this. "So all three are clear."

"All three are clear."

They walked back to the strongroom without speaking. Briggs stood in front of the open chest and looked at it with the expression he used for dice — patient, calculating, reading something other people didn't see.

Blackhoof turned and looked at the door. Then at the lock.

"No sign of force," he said.

"No."

"Which means a key."

"Tusk has the key." Briggs paused. "Had it all night."

Silence.

"He arrived at dawn," Blackhoof said slowly. "Counted the gold himself yesterday evening. Locked it. Kept the key." He looked at Briggs. "And then arrived first thing this morning, unlocked it, and immediately discovered the discrepancy."

"Mm."

"He knew exactly where to look. Exactly what number to expect." Blackhoof's jaw tightened. "Because he'd already been there."

Briggs said nothing. He was looking at the chest with an expression that might, in better light, have been something close to satisfaction.

"The briefing," Blackhoof continued. "He set the assignment himself. He knew we'd be occupied." He thought of the dice game, the candle, the specific corner of the garrison hall where sound carried badly. "He knew your habits."

"Everyone knows my habits."

"He used them." Blackhoof felt something cold settle in his chest that was not quite anger and not quite admiration. "He set you up to take the fall."

Briggs picked up the emptied chest, turned it over, and pointed to the base — a faint scratch in the wood, recent, where something had been pried briefly and replaced. Not a lock. A false bottom. Small, but sufficient for a man who knew the exact contents and had time to plan.

"Found that earlier. While you were standing over there being quiet at me."

Blackhoof looked down at his friend, who was now somehow taller than centaur himself.

"You already knew."

"I had a reasonable hypothesis." He set the chest down. "Now I need a witness."

They found the witness in the stables — one of Tusk's own assistants, a young goblin named Perch who had the nervous energy of someone carrying information he hadn't decided what to do with. It did not take long. Perch, it emerged, had seen Tusk leave his quarters in the middle of the night, had not thought it his place to ask questions, and had been reconsidering that decision for several hours.

Briggs listened. Asked three questions. Thanked him without warmth and left.

The formal accounting took the rest of the morning. Briggs presented the false bottom, the scratch marks, Perch's testimony, and the logical sequence of the key's movements with the flat efficiency of a man submitting inventory paperwork. Tusk denied it with diminishing conviction. By midday, the matter had been referred up the chain, and Tusk had been relieved of his ledger and his rank-chain and escorted to the east wing to keep the garrison sergeant company.

Briggs watched this from the courtyard. Blackhoof came and stood beside him.

For a moment, neither of them spoke.

"Biggs," Blackhoof said.

"Mm."

"I knew you didn't take it." He paused. "I want to say that again, because the first time wasn't quite right."

Briggs looked at him sideways.

"The first time I said I knew you didn't take it," Blackhoof said. "What I should have said was — it didn't matter what you were doing with those dice. I know you." He kept his eyes forward. "I'm sorry for the difference."

Briggs was quiet for a moment. Then he reached into his coat, produced the worn twelve-sided die, and held it out.

Blackhoof looked at it. "What's this for?"

"Pick a number." "Why?"

"Because I'm going to teach you a card game tonight and I want to know how much rope to give you before I start taking your money." The dice rattled on the crest. Eleven.

"Generous," said Briggs, and almost smiled, and walked back inside.

"You know, I am not paid, right?" Smiled Blackhoof.

